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Håkan Rydin

Jazz pianist Håkan Rydin was born in Gislaved, Sweden on January 4, 1951. He led the Nexus Trio from 1972-92, touring the globe and producing critically acclaimed recordings. He has performed with numerous American jazz artists in Europe and he is currently Professor of Jazz Piano at the Malmö Academy of Music at Lund University.

Håkan was interviewed in Glasgow, Scotland on July 27, 2016 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Glasgow with Håkan Rydin.

HR: That's very good.

MR: How'd I do with that?

HR: Very good. In fact much better than I'm used to, but — it's often "Hakan," but it's [sounds like] Hoken in Swedish.

MR: Yeah. You've gotten a lot of variations on that.

HR: Yes. I was performing in the Montreal festival and it was a recording for the radio. And there was a guy who was going to introduce us and he really wanted it correctly. So he spent a lot of time on our Swedish names. And he was pretty nervous about it. And he took notes. It was a French guy, French Canadian. And when he came on to the stage he said, "On piano, [speaks fast] akan redin." But that's fine.

MR: Well we're in Glasgow and you're from Sweden and I'm from America, and it says something about jazz. How's your feeling about coming to a place like this and playing for an international audience?

HR: Well, as you say, jazz is truly international, and maybe more now than ever before. I think now it is not as clear a jazz center in the world like it used to be in New York City and 42nd Street and all that stuff. I mean now, in all of the world, in every town or city of some size you have a jazz club, you have jazz education, and you have enormous festivals. And you have good musicians all over the world. So it's truly international.

MR: Did you ever have aspirations like some European musicians to relocate to New York City?

HR: Well maybe when I was very young. But not really, not really. When I was, as I say, 18, 20, of course I did want to sound like an American musician. We all were. And I remember the first time we went to Canada, to festivals there, at a pretty young age, in the reviews, it said, "typical Scandinavian sound" or "European sound." And we were so sorry about that because we wanted to sound American. But things have changed. I'm 65

now and I'm proud to sound Scandinavian. I'm proud to sound Swedish. And I try to do it, in a way, even if it's international. But I play some Swedish folk music as well.

MR: There's a publication in my state actually, called *New York Cadence Magazine*. They describe your playing as, "quiet but strong."

HR: Oh. I think that was very nice. Yeah. In *Edmonton Journal* they said, "lyrical and cooking." And I was very happy with that.

MR: Yeah. You got both ends of the spectrum.

HR: Yes, yes, yes, yes. And I am very happy.

MR: What was the — I'm trying to remember the European label that recorded American musicians as well as European musicians.

HR: I think ECM.

MR: ECM.

HR: Keith Jarrett is the principal. And many international — I mean they have a very special sound. I mean among the musicians you could talk about the ECM style, typically European. I wouldn't say Keith Jarrett is too much into that but well he had a European group, as you know. But the ECM sound is typically Scandinavian and European.

MR: Is it possible to put that into words? Is it less bluesy?

HR: Yes. Definitely less bluesy. I think affected by the classical music, there's a lot of space, and it's often quite quiet. It's very clean in sound, a very good sound. Quite a lot of even eighths. Straight eighths. Not too much, as you say, they very seldom play blues.

MR: They very seldom?

HR: Play the blues. Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Well it's like well we've got five minutes left on the session, let's do a blues. It's less likely to happen.

HR: Yes, yes, yes, yes.

MR: Well what steered you toward music in your youth?

HR: What?

MR: What, when you were young, how did music grab you?

HR: First of all I've been playing piano all my life. So I have memories as a little child playing by ear the children's songs. And play by ear, that's what I still do. So my mother listened to jazz, to Basie, Louis Armstrong, Ellington, those kind of things. So I got it by the record. I wouldn't say I liked it very much, but I got it natural. I started playing jazz when I was maybe 15, 16. Before that I had some classical education. I played some pop, rock and blues, but when I was 15 or 16 I just started playing jazz, and it just came to me. I don't feel it like a decision. It was just the natural thing to do.

MR: Why wasn't it natural for you to play The Beatles?

HR: Because The Beatles came when I was a teenager, when

[sorry I have to turn this off because something is happening here. It's my son calling, he'll have to wait. Sorry.]

MR: It's your agent with your next gig.

HR: Yeah I wish it was.

MR: Yeah right. No but I think you mentioned, I was going to talk about this later, but I had the pleasure of hearing your trio yesterday.

HR: Yes?

MR: And I thought you mentioned something about The Beatles.

HR: Yes.

MR: And then you played "Here, There and Everywhere" and boy it got me.

HR: Thank you.

MR: Because we had just come from Liverpool and did the whole Beatles — like a pilgrimage. And when you played that song I thought it was wonderful.

HR: Thank you. You recognized it. I played definitely in jazz style, not in pop style. As a jazz ballad.

MR: Yes. Well I could tell you have, in my opinion, you have great respect for the melody.

HR: Thank you.

MR: And you went from that, I was taking notes, and you picked the tempo up and then you were playing this other song and I'm going what is that song. And was I wrong or was it "Where Have All the Flowers Gone"?

HR: You are so correct. Yes. I think I forgot to mention it. But I said I've got to play something which I heard when I grew up. Yeah. It's from Pete Seeger. I think I never heard it in jazz circles.

MR: No. It was nice.

HR: In fact I've played this song, I've played it for a couple of years, not too very long, but I played it in Hanoi, an American guy, in fact I think it was a couple, but a guy came up to me afterwards and he was crying. Because he had such strong memories of the song. So he was touched and me too. It was so nice.

MR: Yeah. It's sort of iconic in the States because the Kingston Trio did it after Pete Seeger, and sometimes people play it in church.

HR: Yes. And it's been translated into many languages.

MR: Right. Well did your parents support your path as a professional musician?

HR: Yes. I had no problems with that. I had those kind of parents that say what you do is fine. That's correct. All the time. But to make it a little more complicated, when I was 18, 19, 20, I mean you decide what to do with your life. Of course I had played jazz for so long I wanted to play jazz. But I also realized that if I was going to be a full time jazz musician I had to lead a very special life and travel a lot and have problems with family life and that.

And so I thought about the options of becoming a music teacher, but it didn't really interest me; classical music — no that wasn't it; dance music was not it; rock music was not the music. So I wanted to play jazz. And I studied at the university, but other things. So when I studied, I studied for let's say 45 minutes by the book and then I'd go 45 minutes by the piano. And that was a perfect combination. Because I could do that forever until I was hungry, you know. And I wouldn't have been a better musician if I'd skipped the university. In the university I did fine. I had good grades, and so it was a pretty good combination. And then after four or five years I got a call from the music academy in Malmö in southwest Sweden where I live, they said, "we are starting a new education." This was in the mid-70s, pretty early. "We are starting the education of jazz and improvisation. Do you want to take part in that?" And I was, even at that time, an established jazz musician in Sweden. So I was the first jazz student in Sweden. There were four of us and we graduated a couple of years later and after that I got one student at the academy. And a couple of years after that I got two or three or four, and then it went on.

MR: Well did they have a — who was instructing you?

HR: We had the best instructors, because we took the musicians who came. Like Thad Jones, I even played a lot with Thad Jones even after the education. We had Don Cherry. I mean fantastic musicians. Billy Hart. Horace Parlan, and so on. They came to play at the local jazz club and the school would hire them for a day and they would play with us. It was a fantastic education. Because of course they weren't teachers at that time.

MR: Well I think you just said we'd play and talk with them. And talking with those people is very informative I find. The lives they led and what it brings to their music.

HR: Yes.

MR: Did you get into accompanying those visiting jazz musicians?

HR: Oh yes. Oh yes. I was in the local trio. I played with some nice musicians. For example I played with Pepper Adams when he was there. That was very interesting.

MR: How so?

HR: Well it was a musical challenge. It was nice. We met in the afternoon to rehearse what we thought. And I got his book. He was traveling by himself at that time. The book with the scores with the music. And I opened it and looked at it and it was written, you know, D flat minor in very big letters you know. Very easy to read. Four bars and four bars, and descending in red you know. So I said oh these are very good, easy, so there would be no mistakes. Then he was very, very friendly. Very laid back. And then we went to dinner. And he was an extremely slow eater. He was talking and talking and talking. It took him three or four hours. So we had a dinner and no rehearsal. So we never had a rehearsal. He

knew the scores were perfect because he used them every night. So he said there should be no mistakes.

MR: And was there a bass player and a drummer on board also?

HR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: So you were all reading from the same book?

HR: Yes. Well of course I knew some of it, and I knew there would be some standards, but most of it I had to read. But he didn't pick very complicated songs. But still. I mean he started every set with an extremely fast blues. He played two choruses of melody, two choruses of solo for everyone in the group, and also he finished every set with that fast blues.

MR: He was playing baritone sax?

HR: Only baritone. Yes. And then one very funny thing, in between sets we went to the bar and sat down there and maybe had a beer or something. And then in came 20 young girls, young women, just around him. I'd never seen that before. I mean he was 60 or 70 or something, bald, and looking like a bank clerk or something. But the women — it was amazing. We were just looking.

MR: Maybe it's the fragrance of the saxophone?

HR: Yeah. Could be. I don't know.

MR: You weren't getting the 15 or 20 women around the piano?

HR: I was not. But I've got a wife of 35 years, same wife.

MR: Did any of those fellows, Thad or Pepper, tell you something useful about accompaniment?

HR: Yes. Playing with Thad Jones was very special. Because he also didn't want to rehearse. And the first time I played with him I asked him, "What do you want to play?" "Well, we'll find out" he said. He didn't say anything what to play. So we went up on stage and you know he talked to the audience. He was very good at introducing and making everyone feel good. He said, "We're going to start up with —" "Now's the Time." Of course he picked songs that in his opinion we should know. Like also, since I got this gig, of course I prepared myself, so I learned his songs, like "Three and One" and "A Child is Born," and "Quietude." So I learned some of his songs to prepare.

MR: How did you go about learning those songs? By ear?

HR: Yes by ear, by listening to records of his.

MR: Yeah. He was so respected. We're the same age. When I was in college we just ate those big band records up, the state-of-the-art sort of. And everybody was shocked in the jazz community when he just up and left the States.

HR: Yes of course.

MR: Did he ever talk about that?

HR: Not really, but he had some great offers. Maybe he wanted to do something by himself. I think the big band he and Mel [Lewis] had was the greatest big band, really. At least at that time, with all those soloists. The reed section, Joe Henderson and Pepper and Jerry Dodgion and Jerome Richardson.

MR: Jerome Richardson.

HR: Amazing. Absolutely amazing. I heard this big band many times when they were touring in Sweden, but I really liked it a lot.

MR: Well you had a long run, longer than most musicians, with one group, with Nexus.

HR: Yes.

MR: How did you manage to stay together so long?

HR: I'm not sure I can answer that, but we in fact stayed together more than 20 years with the same line-up, and we were the same age. We were students to start with. For many years we practiced every day, five days a week, which was also very unusual. I don't want to do it again. But it was fantastic to have that experience. And if you are a jazz musician it's going up and down. So we had certainly some time off but really good times, especially in the early 80s. I know one year we had 127 concerts one year. We were the first Swedish band to tour all over Canada to the big festivals. We had a T.V. program on Wednesday at 8 o'clock, 8 to 9, I mean national T.V. Amazing. So just a couple of years later there were 10 concerts or 15 concerts, without really changing anything. So we had a good time together. We went on good as persons.

MR: Did you have an agency?

HR: No. For a short time but that didn't work.

MR: So you were doing the business yourself?

HR: That's also a thing about being four guys, four persons. We had special roles. I mean I was always doing the music, writing scores, and some composition. And there was one guy who was very good at P.R. and getting gigs. And there was one guy who could find the right places. And the fourth was talking to the audience and doing the interviews. We had a our roles.

MR: And you used a Fender Rhodes?

HR: Yes, in the 70s I did and in the 80s yes. In fact I liked it, I still like the sound of it but it has terrible mechanics. It's not so nice to play on. But I do like the sound. But if I was Herbie Hancock and someone or other brought it for me — but it's I mean, bringing this heavy to a gig and you are like that, and then afterwards you have to take it home. So I got tired of it. So after I think like 25 years I sold it and I got more money selling it than I bought it in the early 70s.

MR: Yes. It'd become a classic.

HR: Yeah.

MR: Did you have the suitcase model? Or the 88?

HR: No I had the 73 suitcase. The first thing I did is I put wheels on it so that indoors I could use it, and I put metal all over, in the corners.

MR: And did you learn how to tune it yourself?

HR: Yes. And you can do a lot with the sound, with how to put the microphones next to it and you can get different sounds if it's like that or if it's like that. And you can also change the mechanics a little. It's still not very good mechanics.

MR: Well let's suppose I had a budget to commission you to write a new piece for a quartet.

HR: Yes.

MR: How do you go about that? Is there a composing process that you do?

HR: Well first I would ask about the deadline. Because — not what we would work for. I think almost every composer, arranger, they end up the last day. I don't think I have a very good answer to that question. I am not that kind of guy who can sit down at 10 o'clock and write a song and write from 10 until 12, as some professional composers do. So I haven't written that many, but I have written all over the years, and I have a couple of songs that I'm happy with. And it's often from an idea. You get an idea — you get it anytime, anywhere. And it can be a melody, it can be a chord progression, it can be a rhythm, it can be a character or something. You get an idea and then you work it out. And if it's — often the best songs are quickly written, but you can always edit. You might notice, I played a new song yesterday, and I wrote it I think about a month ago. And it was like that. I got an idea. I got it almost ready, but the last four bars I had trouble with. So I've learned that you should always complete it. Because always I have lots of ideas that are not completed. So I completed it. And I wasn't happy with it. I rewrote it after a week, I rewrote it three times until I just found out — and then I had to change it. So I will not change it now. But it took some time. But in your own music you are free to edit it if you get a better idea. And it could be sometimes very small things. In this case it was pretty small things. I just found out that it was easier to have another section to do the improvisation, because the melody was pretty long and it was too long to improvise it. So I took parts of it to improvise on. For example, I did a little edit on the edit. I found a new ending.

MR: Sometimes it's hard to know when to stop something.

HR: Yes.

MR: Just leave it.

HR: Yes.

MR: I was trying to determine if the fellas you were playing with — how long you've been playing with them.

HR: Yes that's a very — we met one and a half hours before and we had a 30 minute rehearsal. But I sent the music to them by email in advance.

MR: They did a good job. And at one point, I can't recall the song, but you were playing and you looked up at the bass player and he was looking at you —

HR: Yes?

MR: And the whole band went up a step.

HR: Yes.

MR: Right?

HR: Yes, those amazing moments. I mean that's why it's so nice to play music, isn't it, because it's another kind of communication. It's very direct. [claps] I mean it's like that. I mean we can talk and we can communicate pretty good I hope, but playing is another level, not necessarily higher, but another level of communication. Very direct, very honest in a way. I mean it's there. It should be there.

MR: Let me run a couple of names by you and see if they mean anything. Ramsey Lewis?

HR: Not so very much, yeah? Well of course I've heard it, that's a great piano player.

MR: Yeah. McCoy Tyner?

HR: Definitely. Definitely. Again, when I was at the age where you think about how you want to play, I had four musicians at the generation of McCoy. It was Herbie Hancock, it was McCoy Tyner, it was Chick Corea and it was Keith Jarrett. And then of course there was always Bill Evans. But I wanted to mix those four guys — I don't mean strictly, but that was kind of deliberate. Those were my four most important.

MR: Oh here's an odd one: Bent Fabric.

HR: Don't know.

MR: He was actually a Danish guy.

HR: Yes?

MR: He had that piano hit "The Alley Cat." But it might not have gotten into your consciousness. What about Georgie Fame?

HR: I played with him.

MR: Yeah. They always include it —

HR: So he is very easy to play with. He also brought easy scores to read. I remember the first time, we hadn't played that much but we played a couple of times. We made a tour. The first time I played with him we were supposed to do a radio recording, and at the same time a whole night at a jazz club, three sets or something like that. So we rehearsed. We rehearsed in the afternoon, and there was also two horns. So we got some arrangements. And it was a lot of things. I mean a whole night of music, it was a lot of things really. And then there was one song, what's the name — "On a Misty Night" and that was only the harmonies. C major, E minor, A flat major, D minor 7. Very easy to read. 32 bars.

And we rehearsed that song. And then when I came home at night after playing, of all this music, it was this song that went in my head. [humms] It's a very, very simple song in a way, but still unique, it's Tadd Dameron. I wrote it down, and he sang it very straight in a slow/medium tempo and with nothing special, but it was nice and it was a lot appreciated by the audience. And the day after, I told him this story. Do you know which song I was thinking about, it was "On a Misty Night." And he said, "Yeah, that happens all the time. It's always popular by all musicians. It's nice to improvise on. It's simple but it has some challenges and some character, some definite character. So it's a nice song, really.

MR: I'll have to check it out. I didn't even know he did that kind of music. We're mostly familiar with a couple of his hits.

HR: Yeah but he did a lot of jazz, and a lot of vocalese. You know, like Jon Hendricks things.

MR: Oh, Jon Hendricks, one of my favorites.

HR: Yeah. Me too.

MR: And you spent some years accompanying Kim Parker?

HR: Yes I did. We played I think almost 15 years off and on. Of course not all the time but off and on. And I still have contact with her. I also got to know her fantastic mother, Chan Parker, the wife of Bird. So for example we went to her home, she lived outside Paris, in a 200 year old house or something, and at the bottom floor it was just one big room. It had a kitchen where you eat, you had the living room, and you had the music department. So it was like that. And on the walls there was "Best Alto Saxophone Player '47, '48, '49." The *Down Beat* award. For Bird. And there was a big painting that Bird did. Maybe you know, he was also a great painter, painting in oil. And it was a painting he did in the late 40s, a big painting. It looks exactly like Kim Parker when she is 25 or 30. It's amazing. You can't explain it. It's like a portrait. But he did it when Kim was two years old.

MR: I wonder if Chan was able to live off any of Charlie Parker's estate, or if there was such a thing.

HR: To some extent but they very seldom got anything from the record companies, because Bird didn't have that kind of agreement. He had a cash payment. No contracts. They got a lot of money from Clint Eastwood when they made the film. Clint was very nice to the family, inviting them for the premier and talking to them in the production, so he did good and the family had the two saxes, saxophones, so first they sold the plastic —

MR: The white plastic sax?

HR: The plastic sax. They got a lot of money for that. The other one I won't talk about. But they said it was like their insurance.

MR: Yeah. Did he have a profound effect on you? Charlie Parker himself?

HR: No, not just like the most amazing music you can ever imagine. I never really tried to play that way. And I don't perform his songs. And in fact Kim never sings Charlie Parker's songs. And in the start of her career she didn't even use the name. She called her Kim Ibeko. You know she didn't want to be associated with — she didn't want to live under her father's name. And then of course she changed. It would be stupid not to do that.

MR: So you're in academia now.

HR: Yes.

MR: Is that a full time gig for you?

HR: Well officially it is, yes. I'm the only professor of jazz piano in Sweden. I was appointed three years ago, which I'm very happy about. It meant more freedom, it meant much less education, so I think I'm a better teacher now because I can prepare more activity, I can take it at a slow tempo, I can have some space between students, and as I said, not so much teaching, and more money. So I'm really happy about it. Oh sorry, it also meant the fact that I can come here.

MR: Right. You have some freedom in your schedule.

HR: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: Do the students who come to you now know more than they used to?

HR: Well I think it differs very, very much, between individuals. First of all their knowledge of history differs. Some know everything, and some know nothing. Some don't know who Oscar Peterson is. Some know more than me about history and can compete for record deals. So it's a big difference. And I don't think it's changed so much over the years. They're good.

MR: Do you like the fact that everything is available to them through the internet and so forth?

HR: Well I think — of course you can't fight it, but when I learned jazz, as I said, I learned it from the records or by listening, or in some part by playing with people. So I have transcribed so many songs. In the group Nexus for example, I did the chords and the saxophone player did the melody. So when there was a Wayne Shorter album or something it could take two months to take out those strange chords. Now you've got it, you can pay for it, you've got it on the internet. So the situation is of course totally different. I got to practice by my ear and of course it's good to have done that. But I mean you can't change it.

MR: Right. Didn't you write a book about playing by ear?

HR: Yes. In fact two. *Play Piano by Ear*. But it's in Swedish.

MR: Okay.

HR: What I also have done, which I'm happy to be doing, is I've been working quite a lot in Hanoi, in Vietnam, helping them to build their jazz education. And now they have jazz

education with lots of students and lots of piano players. In fact I'm going there again next week but I've been there I think eight or nine times and I've been working like a month at a time at the academy teaching and working with the administration, how to give good education and teaching the teachers, and playing, performing. So I've got a lot of friends there and I perform there quite a lot.

MR: And what language do you communicate in?

HR: English of course, but I have to have a translator most of the time because not all of them know English. So it takes a little time.

MR: Well let's suppose I had a grandson who was 15.

HR: Yes?

MR: And really wanted to be a jazz musician, and I sent him to you for some advice.

HR: It wouldn't be so much work. What I do, I do a lot of playing together. In my room at the school I have two good Steinway grand pianos. So we play a lot together. I teach a lot by ear. I teach songs by ear. It takes a little longer time but I reach some other things that you don't when you only go by the paper. So that's what I do a lot.

MR: Do you think students today need to have other skills than the jazz musician of the 1950s?

HR: They have to have knowledge about society. Maybe you needed it at that time, but I mean how to get a gig, how to write a contract, and things like that. How to manage your home page and YouTube and all that kind of stuff maybe. I think that's needed today. Most of us don't have someone to do it.

MR: Right. Well this isn't exactly a jazz question but in the current, the news every day seems to — is not great.

HR: You're right.

MR: And we don't usually hear Sweden and Scandinavian countries mentioned with all this — some of these horrible things that are going on. Is there a reason for that?

HR: Well I think we used to have a very good society in Sweden. We've got, as everyone knows, very high taxes. But we get another thing from our high taxes. We get free health care, we get free education. Even the university is free for everyone. So we get a lot of things back from our taxes. I think today Sweden is more like other countries now than it used to be. Good and bad I guess. Basically I think it's a good society to live in. A good country to live in.

MR: And do you play much in Sweden?

HR: No. In fact I play more abroad than I do in Sweden. Last month I did one concert in Malmo where I played solo piano. But I very seldom play at our local jazz clubs I'm sorry to say. I don't know why.

MR: What's your favorite format to play?

HR: Trio. Definitely trio. Small groups. Trio, duo, quartet, solo. Because when I started playing piano it was not so interesting to play big band piano — Count Basie or something. With Thad Jones and Mel Lewis, like we talked about, things changed. Because then the rhythm section was so central in the big band. So then I started to play the piano. But I had already made my choice. But I mean to organize a big band, I wouldn't dream of it. I mean it needs some special capacities to do that. I'm not that kind of guy. A trio is fantastic. I think piano, bass and drums is three instruments made to play together. It sounds so great together. And a horn would be nice, or a singer. A singer is quite a lot.

MR: Because you get to play either by choice or by necessity with different bassists and drummers —

HR: Yes?

MR: What would a bassist or a drummer do that might annoy you?

HR: I find problems when they have too little personal input. If they always ask me what I want — sometimes in Asia they are fantastic. They do exactly what you say and that's amazing of course, but I want it to be cooperation. So as I said, I play a lot with different rhythm sections. And I mean next week I'm going to play with a rhythm section in Vietnam and the week after that I'm going to Malaysia to play with a new rhythm section. My way of doing it is I try not to tell people too much what to do. I tell them to let us take the music where it goes. So I can be happy with a soft drummer, I can be happy with a loud drummer. As long as it's not one dynamic all the time. So it's not soft all the time or loud all the time or medium all the time. I do prefer dynamics in musicians. And when I get that I'm happy. And if you, you do your best to add some dynamics.

MR: Well I'm guessing you give them more information than Thad Jones gave to you.

HR: I definitely need to do that. I try to put, like Pepper Adams, very easy to read scores. I do Finale by computer. And I send PDFs. I could do a red circle, "last time to coda" circle. Here's the coda. Okay? Play always this key or something like that. I say this style, this is even eighths, this is swing, this is a ballad. So I give some information in the scores, but not too much. The important — I mean of course it's nice to get the forms right, that the bridge comes where the bridge should come. I mean that's the basic. But apart from that, it can be very different from night to night and it can be different from rhythm section to rhythm section. Some songs I change. Some songs I can change tempo and character from day to day. Some songs I play more the same all the time.

MR: Was the drummer reading the same chart as the bass player yesterday?

HR: Yes. And I try not to send too complicated — I mean it's another thing if I work with my own trio, I can work on totally other things. On meter, other kinds of arrangements. I

don't want to make it too complicated. I want to be able to come into the music and communicate.

MR: There's nothing like watching the drummer and he's got his music stand over here, and that's where his focus is, on the music stand.

HR: Yes, yes, yes. But that was the first time we'd played. But somewhat —he looked at me.

MR: Yeah. It was delightful. This is always a hard question. Can you recall a best gig ever and a worst gig ever?

HR: Well there are some gigs that you certainly remember. I don't really — I mean we had an amazing experience in Montreal when we were supposed to play outside and there was some highway or something we were supposed to play. And where we ended up it was crowded with people. I had never played with such — that was a big experience. But I think I can mention another one. We had a gig, in fact in my home town, we had been on tour, and the last day we had a long, long, long travel, I mean ten hours in the bus or something like that. And it was at the end of a tour and we were tired and we were a little bit sick and we had this long travel, and we just ended up saying we can't possibly play, this must be the most terrible situation. So we just sat down and think nothing will happen. But it was an amazing concert. One of the best we did. About the worst, I will tell a little story. Of course there are not many situations where you are not happy with what's happening — coming in and finding an empty place or something. All musicians have had that experience. But I can tell you about the last concert with Nexus, when we decided to finish the group, after a little more than 20 years. At that point of course everyone wanted to do their best, to have a good memory of an ending. And in a way I think it was a very concentrated concert with very few mistakes and many things happening. And then we had an encore, and then we played — I don't know the English word the theme of the group, or what do you call it, a song you always play that is connected to you. So this was a song we always played, and played forever. And we made a mistake on that song. Because everything was a big success, and so we could play it in our sleep, and we kind of f***ed it up a little bit. And that was very embarrassing. I still remember that feeling. Some mistakes of communication.

MR: Right I see. So that was your last number.

HR: Yeah. In a way it was.

MR: Sort of inevitable I guess.

HR: Yeah.

MR: Any Swedish musicians that you particularly took note of?

HR: Yes. I will mention one specifically. Of course there are many. There's Lars Gullin. And he was a little bit famous even in the States. He was on the *Down Beat* list. And what he did, in the 50s and 60s, he was influenced by the Nordic classical music. And maybe

that's not so very unique, especially later. But what he wrote songs inspired by that music but he made it into genuine jazz. Songs that were nice to play on, nice to improvise on. He really was a great composer. Fantastic musician, with a tragic life I'm sorry to say, but some great songs he wrote. At least in his early days he was a very melodic saxophone player like Stan Getz — not really — but very melodic and very beautiful.

MR: Beautiful baritone.

HR: Yeah.

MR: I wonder why the jazz life is connected sometimes to abuse of narcotics and all that. It's unfortunate.

HR: Well I don't know so much about it. I think times have changed also. When I started to play, in my generation, it was quite a lot the opposite, you know? You were supposed to be a vegetarian and drink water and green tea and things like that. I never drink anything before I play. It doesn't work on me. It could work on a lot of people, I mean it's an individual choice. I don't play that good. I think I get chancy and not in control. I can enjoy a beer after the concert, surely.

MR: Okay last — here's a very easy question to wrap up. What do you think about when you improvise?

HR: Yes. Very easy. How many hours do we have? I guess — I think you play best when you don't think. But it's not easy to say that. And you can't say now I'm not going to think. But if that's some state of mind, some feeling that every jazz musician knows when you have flow when things are happening and you could just do things maybe you haven't done before and things like that. At that moment you don't think. But some people call it a peak experience or something. And maybe in a whole concert it happens once or even it sometimes doesn't happen. Sometimes if you are lucky you can have many peaks of experience, and you try to reach that but it's not so easy of course, it's very difficult to reach them. I think it's two things going on. You have to be concentrated and you have to be relaxed. And those are — if you're concentrated you might be too concentrated, and if you are too relaxed you make mistakes. So it's relaxed and concentrated, and it's very difficult. But if you can maximize both of them I think you have a good possibility of playing good. And then you don't think that much. But of course you think and you've got some idea of what to play. I can get influenced by what's happening before. So if I play with a saxophone player and he played eight choruses of really groovy things, maybe I'll try to play soft, or very little. I mean that's a deliberate choice at that moment, but it wasn't decided before. If you think things are a little unstable in the band I try to play very simple, I try to make it swing. If I think nothing is happening I try to put some energy into it and do some counter-rhythm or something like that. So it depends on what's happening and what's happened before.

MR: That was an excellent answer to a tough question.

HR: Thank you.

MR: Well I've really enjoyed talking with you.

HR: Thank you. It was nice talking to you. Thank you.

MR: And best of luck in your travels and your concert tomorrow night.

HR: Thank you.

MR: All right. Over and out.